

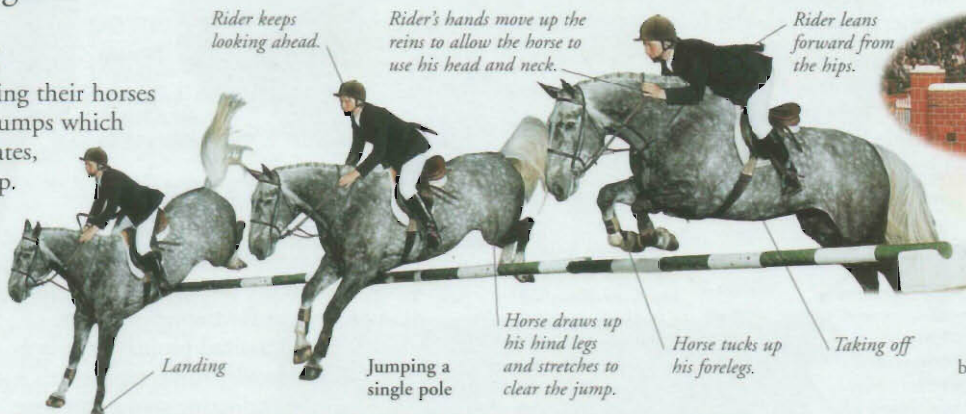
HORSE RIDING



PEOPLE RIDE HORSES for leisure and in competitions, which are often described as equestrian (from *equus*, meaning horse). These include show jumping, eventing, and dressage, all of which test the horse's ability to jump or perform special movements, and each of which appears in the Olympic programme. Equestrian events also include racing events – flat racing, steeplechasing, and hurdling – where jockeys ride specially bred horses called thoroughbreds. Other riding sports include polo, in which teams of riders compete to score goals.

Show jumping

This involves riders taking their horses around a set course of jumps which may include artificial gates, a wall, and a water jump. Competitors receive faults if their horse refuses or knocks down a jump, or exceeds the specified time. The competitor with the fewest faults wins.



Puissance
This show jumping competition tests the ability of a horse to jump high fences. From four to six fences are jumped, the number being reduced and the height raised for each round.

Racing

Racing can be flat or over jumps. Some events such as the English Grand National – a steeplechase – are world famous and attract thousands of spectators and involve heavy betting on different runners. Horses may have to carry extra weights under the saddle, as well as the jockey (rider).

Polo

This game is played four-a-side on a large field. Players mounted on polo ponies use mallets to strike a ball into their opponents' goal. A game consists of up to eight seven-minute periods called chukkers. Riders usually change ponies after every chukker.



Dressage

In dressage, each competitor guides his or her horse through paces, figures, manoeuvres, and halts (stops). Judges award points for the quality of the performance. Dressage is a formal sport and riders wear top hat and tails or military uniform; it needs a high degree of discipline and schooling.



English Derby

Flat racing

Horses are raced over distances from 5 furlongs (1 km) to 2 miles (3 km) or more. Many countries follow the English tradition of Classic races for three-year-olds, which include a Derby, and for fillies (young female horses), an Oaks, over 1.5 miles (2.4 km).

Grand National



Jumping

The main types of jumping races are hurdling, for three-year-old horses upwards, and steeplechasing for four-year-olds upwards. Hurdles are low and may be knocked over; steeplechase fences are larger and include ditches and water jumps.

Eventing

In three-day eventing, riders take their horses through a different discipline each day to test all aspects of the horse's abilities. Dressage tests a horse's obedience and show jumping its powers of recovery. There is also a four-phase endurance test which includes a steeplechase.



Cross-country

The cross-country phase may cover 7 km (4.3 miles) with about 30 fixed obstacles of all kinds. The course has to be completed in a set time to avoid time penalties. The jumps are often spectacular and include water, slippery grass banks, steps, solid walls, and drops.

Mark Todd

A New Zealand eventer, Mark Todd (b. 1956) won the individual three-day event gold medal at the 1984 and 1988 Olympics on the horse Charisma. He was deprived of a third successive gold when his mount broke down on the second day after scoring well in the dressage.



FIND OUT
MORE

EVOLUTION

HORSES

MAMMALS

MONGOL
EMPIRE

OLYMPIC
GAMES

SPORT